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Popular versus Orthodox Islam

When I came to Kanuba at the beginning of 1947, Hag Abdullah was the imam of the mosque. Actually, he has been the imam since the village settled in 1933. When I came, I found the two extremes in religious practice. The popular Islamic group was headed by Sheikh Salama. The majority of the village followed him. Sheikh Muhammad was one of his followers, and now, since Salama left, he leads the popular Islamic group. People liked to listen to Sheikh Salama. He is a very persuasive speaker, and he makes people enjoy themselves and laugh. He liked to laugh and sit with people on the *mastaba* [outdoor stone bench usually built into the side of a house]. At the time, he was dynamic and persuasive. His arguments were strong, and he knew how to give evidence and be logical. Sheikh Salama is wise, an *afreet kibir*.^{*} He is a modern sheikh. That is why people of all ages like him. Even though he jokes and smiles and sings songs, he is a good Muslim.

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When Sheikh Salama was here, he used to give a zikr in the mosque or outside several times a week. He comes from a family of zikr givers. Even now in new Diwan his brother also leads the zikrs. Actually Sheikh Salama is in harmony with the Old Nubian tradition of Islam. When I first came here, zikrs were very strong in the village and very popular. When Sheikh Salama made a zikr, he even invited the people from Daraw and they came. He was a dynamo. He organized many things and kept the custom of the zikr going. When he held the zikr, he lined the men up in two rows with the chanter at the head of the first row. They would begin a rhythmic motion with their head and body and repeat one word such as "Allah!" We don't have them very much any

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more. When Sheikh Salama left, the zikrs declined, especially because the imam is against them.

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When I came here, Hag Abdullah's group, which is sometimes called the Wahabis by the others, was in the minority. We had few followers in comparison to Sheikh Salama. But Hag Abdullah wants to force religion on the people as if he were spoon-feeding medicine. He is always talking about what Islam prohibits, whereas Sheikh Salama always talked about what Islam permits. That is why the people preferred to listen to him. People like to enjoy themselves.

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I can remember many disputes between these two groups in those early days. On the *mastaba*, in the mosque, and in the houses, arguments  119 always took place whenever Sheikh Salama and Hag Abdullah came together for any reason. They always drew crowds around them. As I said, Sheikh Salama's arguments were strong. Hag Abdullah is an extremist. He likes to impress people with his dignity. He never jokes, and he doesn't listen to music or allow dancing. However, he has a weak personality and is not intelligent. He would have had no chance to promote his ideas if Abdul, my brother, had not come to the village to help me with the farming at the same time that I came in 1947. When Abdul came, Hag Abdullah saw this as an opportunity to promote his ideas, because Abdul is a fanatic Wahabi and a strong speaker. Actually, Abdul and I believe the same things, but our methods are different; he is a fanatic, but I am flexible.

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*Literally, "big jinn or spirit"—a colloquial term meaning a person who likes to joke and has an exceptionally animated personality.

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